market. Today, they are generally known to outsiders as those engaging in commercial occupations and having roots in Rajasthan.

The term ‘Marwari’ dates back to the founding of business houses outside Rajasthan, in Bengal, Bihar and Orissa during the Mughal rule.[47] These links are said to have been established through the Rajput army on the Mughal side as many traders and *modi*s (suppliers to the army) accompanied them. Over time, they established themselves along key towns of the Gangetic waterways and also extended their network towards central Asia. Apart from trading, banking was also a prominent activity as land revenues in many regions were paid in cash. As Mughal power declined in the 18th century, merchant-bankers became important for exchanging coins, financing trade and brokering political power. According to one historian, ‘from Astrakan [in Russia] to Dacca, finance and commerce came to be dominated by the Marwaris in the first half of the 18th century.’[48] The most famous firm was the house of Jagat Seth (‘banker of the world’), the Oswal Jains who were most likely from Bikaner and served the Nawabs of Bengal in Murshidabad and financed European trade before eventually playing a key role in securing victory for the British in the Battle of Plassey in 1757.[49] The subsequent decline of Murshidabad and the rise of Calcutta in eastern India, mirroring the decline of Surat and the rise of Bombay in western India, led to a new wave of Marwari migrations to both upcoming cities. The number of Marwaris in Calcutta rose from eighty in 1813 to 600 in 1833.[50]

As British rule slowly consolidated over the Indian subcontinent, Marwaris participated in the cotton, cloth and opium trade in north Indian urban centres, financed through the intricate hundi system of bills of exchange. In the Maratha and Hyderabad courts, they worked as bankers and contractors. With commercialization of agriculture in the 19th century, Marwaris also found a role as moneylenders in rural areas. Just like the Chettiars, the Marwari network began to expand in the hinterland between Bombay and Calcutta, through agents, associations and a certain amount of asceticism. Young men would set forth to new towns, live in congested *bassa*s or collective messes run by Marwari firms and associations, and